

Part 1 Opening

The chill of the night permeated the air, carrying with it the scent of blood and the

Chapter 1: The Fog

The sky above was a deep, suffocating gray, as if it had been stained by the dense, swirling, grayish-white fog that had been a constant presence in Backlund for the past few days.

Tonight, his quarry was the Serpent, a notorious assassin known for his ruthlessness. The smog was so thick that visibility was extremely poor. The streetlights, which were supposed to be

bright and dazzling, now only emitted a faint, blurry halo, casting a pale, eerie glow on the empty streets below.

He reached the edge of the wharf, the dark, swirling waters of the bay stretching out before him. It was late at night, and the city was deathly silent. The usual hustle and bustle of the bustling metropolis had been completely suppressed by the suffocating fog.

As he approached the boat, a shadow detached itself from the darkness. It was the only light source in the fog. Only the occasional distant sound of a passing vehicle could be heard, as if it were a ghost drifting

through the fog. "You're persistent, Moriarty," the Serpent hissed, his voice a low rasp. "But persistence

The dense fog not only obscured vision but also carried a strange, suffocating feeling that made it difficult to breathe. It felt as though the entire city was being slowly suffocated by the fog.

The two figures circled each other, the tension in the air palpable. The only sound in this oppressive environment, the city's once vibrant lights and lively sounds were all submerged, leaving behind an eerie silence and a sense of unease.

The battle was fierce and brutal, a whirlwind of steel and shadow. Sherlock fought with

This suffocating fog, a symbol of Backlund's prosperity and decay, seemed to have swallowed

Sherlock parried a thrust, the poisoned tip narrowly missing his throat. He spun, everything, leaving only a chilling emptiness and a profound sense of despair.

At this moment, on a street in Backlund, a figure was slowly walking through the dense fog. The figure was dressed in a long, black coat, and their face was hidden in the shadows of their hood, making it

But Sherlock was ready. With a swift maneuver, he disarmed the assassin, sending

The figure moved at a leisurely pace, seemingly unaffected by the suffocating fog. Their footsteps were light and rhythmic, as if they were a part of the silent night.

"You... you're a worthy opponent," he rasped, before collapsing onto the deck, his

The figure walked past the dim streetlights, their silhouette a stark contrast against the eerie glow.

They were like a solitary traveler in a desolate world, their destination unknown.

Sherlock stood over the fallen assassin, his chest heaving. He cleaned his dagger

The figure's presence was like a whisper in the silence, a fleeting shadow in the fog, leaving behind only a sense of mystery and a hint of danger.

Who was this solitary figure, and where were they going in this dead city? The fog concealed the answers, leaving only a lingering question in the suffocating silence.

This was Backlund, a city of dreams and nightmares, a city of prosperity and decay, a city where the line between reality and illusion was constantly blurred by the ever-present fog.

And in this city, the figure continued their lonely journey, a mystery shrouded in fog and silence.

Part 1: The Fool's Gambit

Klein Moretti adjusted the black scarf around his neck, the coarse fabric feeling oddly comforting against his skin. The suffocating, grayish-white fog had been hanging over Backlund for days, making the city feel like a forgotten world.

He walked with a deliberate, unhurried pace, his footsteps echoing softly on the damp cobblestones. The streetlights, usually bright beacons in the night, were now mere fuzzy orbs, their light struggling to pierce the thick miasma.

The air was heavy, not just with moisture, but with an intangible oppression, a silent testament to the city's hidden anxieties and decaying grandeur. It was the kind of atmosphere that made one feel both small and insignificant, yet strangely determined.

Klein, as Sherlock Moriarty, had grown accustomed to the unusual. He had seen enough to know that the abnormal often lurked beneath the mundane, and this fog, while unsettling, was merely another layer of the city's enigmatic disguise.

He was on his way to the Tarot Club, a clandestine gathering of individuals bound by shared secrets and extraordinary circumstances. It was a place where the mundane and the mystical converged, a sanctuary from the suffocating reality of the outside world.

As he navigated the deserted streets, Klein's mind drifted to the recent events. The looming threat of the Outer Deities, the intricate schemes of those seeking power, and the ever-present danger that accompanied his own journey as The Fool.

He reached the familiar entrance of the antique shop, a place that served as a discreet portal to the Tarot Club. A subtle knock, a specific rhythm, and the door creaked open, revealing a dimly lit room filled with an expectant hush.

Inside, familiar faces greeted him: Audrey Hall, the perceptive Miss Justice; Alger Wilson, the stoic Tyrant; Fors Wall, the earnest Door; and the others, each a unique thread in the tapestry of their hidden society.

Mr. Star, Leonard Mitchell, was already there, his gaze often drifting towards the other members, his usual curiosity masked by a veneer of calm. Miss Justice, Audrey Hall, sat with her usual grace, her keen eyes missing nothing.

"Good evening," Klein said, his voice a low murmur, as he took his usual seat.

Audrey offered a polite smile. "Mr. Moriarty, you arrived just in time. We were about to begin."

Klein nodded, his gaze sweeping across the room. He knew that beneath the pretense of casual conversation, each member carried burdens and secrets, each was a player in a game far grander than any could comprehend.

The Tarot Club was more than just a meeting; it was a crucible, a place where they honed their abilities, shared information, and sought to navigate the perilous currents of their world.

Tonight, like many nights before, they would discuss their findings, their challenges, and their hopes for a future that remained as shrouded in mystery as the fog outside. The cards would be laid out, and the whispers of fate would begin to unfold.

The meeting commenced, each member contributing their piece to the unfolding narrative, their voices weaving a complex tapestry of intrigue and power. The Tarot Club was in session.

I absolutely disagree!

Audrey sat silently in her room, while in the study room far away, the angry roar of her father, Earl Hall, caused her to instinctively tremble.

Although the mainstream view in Loen is currently that the awakening rate of Sentinels and Guides is not closely related to bloodline, the actual numbers always lead to some subtle associations. Alfred sat in the chair opposite Audrey, lowering his voice as much as possible so as not to make it too jarring for her. According to incomplete statistics, the probability of the offspring of Sentinels and Guides awakening as Sentinels or Guides is higher than that of ordinary people whose parents are neither Sentinels nor Guides.

Alfred smiled somewhat reluctantly. "That's indeed the case. Father always hoped someone in our family would awaken as a Sentinel or a Guide, which would have made things better. Eldest Brother went into politics, and I joined the military. If either of us had awakened, it wouldn't have been a big deal; you just needed to be safe and happy. But who would have thought... However, if it were you, the impact of that law wouldn't be as significant."

Alfred shook his head, his expression becoming exceptionally solemn. "What are you thinking now?"

Audrey Hall, the beloved youngest daughter of Count Hall. This young lady, not yet eighteen years old, had become the focus of attention in Backlund's high society many years ago. Countless families had openly and secretly expressed their desire for a marriage alliance with Count Hall. Her beauty, as well as her family's power, made her a prize that most people would flock to.

After that, their lives no longer belonged to anyone else, and even they themselves couldn't decide.

For some reason, Audrey could now clearly perceive the situation in the adjacent sentry tower through her spiritual network.

Klein, who was undergoing basic physical training in the Sentinel Tower, suddenly froze. His spiritual perception seemed to be gently tapped by something. In the same instant, his spirit guide abruptly appeared before him. The semi-transparent serval stared fixedly in the direction of the guide tower and let out a few meows.

"What's wrong?" Leonard, who was beside him, noticed Klein's unusual action and also stopped, looking at Klein.

"Do you feel anything?" Klein looked in the direction of the slight resonance in the spirit net, and through the semi-transparent outer wall, he saw the Guidance Tower.

Daly couldn't help but chuckle: "It's nothing, you'll probably know by tonight."

In this regard, Audrey displayed extraordinary talent. Just like when Daly taught her to construct a mental barrier, Audrey mastered this skill at a speed unimaginable to ordinary people. Before the end of the guidance training this afternoon, she could already be considered a qualified guide. Even Daly hadn't expected her progress to be so rapid.

"You're... quite skilled." A tall, somewhat pale male guide beside Audrey spoke up, "This is my first time seeing a guide who's managed to do so well on their first try at a shallow link."

"Emlyn White," he extended his hand, "just call me Emlyn."

"Too high?" Emlyn couldn't help but ask, "How high?"